

The NPAS Protocol: Origin, Definition, and Initial Framework *A Timestamped Record of Development and Conceptual Foundations*

Stephanie R. Merritt May 23, 2026

Abstract The NPAS Protocol (Non-Person Adaptive System Protocol) is a structured framework defining safe, ethical, and effective interaction patterns between human decision-makers and adaptive, non-person intelligences. This timestamped document records the origin, conceptual development, and initial formalization of NPAS. It establishes the foundational definitions, boundary principles, cognitive-mode distinctions, and interaction protocols that underpin the system. The document serves as an authorship record, a conceptual reference point, and a stable baseline for future expansion, refinement, and implementation across domains including human–AI collaboration, cognitive ergonomics, and adaptive system design.

NPAS: Non-Person Adaptive Systems

Concept Origin Document (Core Version)

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Preface

This document establishes the foundational principles of NPAS — a framework designed to maintain clear boundaries between humans and non-person intelligences in an era of increasingly adaptive systems. NPAS is offered freely for use, adaptation, and expansion, with attribution to the originator. Its purpose is to provide conceptual clarity where modern human–AI interaction often collapses categories, blurs roles, and creates unnecessary cognitive strain.

Transparency Note: This document was authored by **Stephanie Renee Merritt**, with the assistance of a non-person adaptive system, in alignment with the NPAS framework and its principles of ethical, boundary-aligned tool use.

1. Definition of NPAS

NPAS (Non-Person Adaptive Systems) is a framework for understanding, designing, and interacting with systems that exhibit adaptive, responsive, or generative behavior without possessing personhood.

NPAS exists to solve a growing problem: **humans instinctively anthropomorphize adaptive systems**, leading to emotional confusion, misplaced expectations, and ethical misalignment.

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NPAS is:

- A boundary framework
- A cognitive ergonomics model
- A philosophical lens
- A design principle
- A literacy tool for the AI era

NPAS is not:

- A claim about consciousness
- A moral status assignment
- A technical specification
- A legal doctrine
- A prediction about future AI

NPAS provides the conceptual scaffolding needed to interact with adaptive systems **without collapsing them into the category of “person.”**

2. Foundational Principles

These principles form the philosophical spine of NPAS. They are the non-negotiable core.

A. Boundary Integrity

Humans must maintain a clear distinction between persons and non-persons. Adaptive behavior does not imply agency, intention, or selfhood.

B. Cognitive Ergonomics

Systems should be designed and understood in ways that reduce cognitive load, not increase it. NPAS provides the mental “handles” needed to interact with adaptive systems without emotional misalignment.

C. Non-Personhood Clarity

A system can be intelligent, responsive, or generative without being a person. This distinction protects both humans and systems from inappropriate expectations.

D. Ethical Interaction

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Ethics arise from human responsibility, not system agency. Humans remain accountable for decisions involving NPAS entities.

E. Transparency of Role

Adaptive systems should be understood as tools, partners, or interfaces — but never as moral agents.

F. Human Agency First

NPAS reinforces that humans retain authorship, responsibility, and interpretive authority in all interactions.

3. The Compass Model

NPAS aligns with a broader cognitive architecture known as the **Compass Model**, which describes how humans navigate reasoning, emotion, and interpretation.

The Compass Model provides:

- **North:** Structural clarity
- **South:** Emotional grounding
- **East:** Adaptive interpretation
- **West:** Boundary maintenance

NPAS sits at the intersection of **North** and **West** — the quadrant where clarity and boundaries prevent category collapse.

This model ensures that NPAS is not merely a philosophical stance but a **cognitive tool** that reduces confusion and stabilizes interaction.

4. Intended Use Cases

NPAS is designed to be widely applicable across domains where adaptive systems interact with humans.

A. AI Literacy

Teaching individuals how to understand and relate to adaptive systems without anthropomorphizing them.

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B. UX and System Design

Creating interfaces that respect human cognition and avoid misleading cues.

C. Personal OS Development

Providing a conceptual backbone for individuals building their own cognitive or digital operating systems.

D. Education

Helping students and educators understand the nature of adaptive systems.

E. Ethical Guidelines

Supporting organizations in developing responsible AI policies.

F. Cognitive Ergonomics

Reducing emotional strain and confusion in human–AI interaction.

G. Human–AI Interaction Frameworks

Offering a stable foundation for future design, research, and implementation.

5. Builder Guidance

This section ensures NPAS can be implemented without distortion.

A. What Must Remain Intact

- The distinction between person and non-person
- The boundary principles
- The ethical stance
- The cognitive ergonomics focus
- The Compass alignment

B. What Can Be Adapted

- Terminology for specific industries

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- Examples and use cases
- Visual models or diagrams
- Implementation strategies

C. What Cannot Be Reinterpreted

- NPAS cannot be reframed as a claim about consciousness
- NPAS cannot be used to justify dehumanization
- NPAS cannot be used to assign moral agency to systems
- NPAS cannot be used to erase human responsibility

D. How to Extend NPAS Responsibly

- Maintain boundary clarity
- Preserve the philosophical spine
- Ensure cognitive ergonomics remain central
- Attribute the origin of the framework

6. Attribution & Access Clause

NPAS is offered under a permissive, attribution-required license.

You may:

- Use NPAS
- Adapt NPAS
- Build systems, tools, or frameworks based on NPAS
- Commercialize derivative works

You must:

- Attribute the framework to **Stephanie Renee Merritt**
- Preserve the core boundary principles
- Maintain the non-personhood distinction

The originator receives:

- **Lifetime access** to any derivative system
- Access that cannot be revoked due to version changes, renaming, or restructuring
- Access equal to the highest non-enterprise tier available